Bengal. Among these states, the terms offered by West Bengal looked particularly attractive.

'In 2006, West Bengal offered Tata an incentive package few industrialists could resist, including a 1,000 acre plot of land virtually for free, a Rs 2 bn loan, cheap electricity and an exemption from 12.5 per cent value-added tax for 10 years,' wrote the *Financial Times*. Both Ratan and West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharjee had initially hoped to establish the plant in Kharagpur, which they believed would be an 'anchor investment which will lead to the future economic growth in the entire district'. The land at Kharagpur was already identified by the state for an industrial park. Tata Motors agreed, only to change its mind soon.

Ratan preferred a location closer to the state capital, Kolkata. The choice finally fell on Singur, a small town about 50 km from the capital. Situated along the national highway, it provided great connectivity and was close to the airport. It was selected because of its higher visibility. This site was preferred by Kant, who was shown the lands as well. Once the site was approved, Singur, which was virtually unknown until then, gained worldwide attention. But the choice of location left a lot to be desired.

The announcement of the project was made on 18 May 2006; interestingly, the same day Bhattacharjee began his second innings as chief minister. Many, however, found the choice of Singur inexplicable. West Bengal was notorious for being a hotbed of labour militancy. Even the Tata Motors team was divided on its choice. But finally, Ratan prevailed over them. He argued that it would help the investment-starved state in its quest for development. 'Tata Motors will be investing over Rs 1,500 crore in the proposed facility in Singur, which would create jobs, directly and indirectly, for about 10,000 people,' Ratan said in a letter to Bhattacharjee.

Within a week of the announcement of the Nano project, agitations started in Singur against the state government's proposal to take over 997 acres of farmland under the 1894 Land Acquisition Act. Singur was the most fertile belt in the region and most of the local population was dependent on agriculture for its livelihood. It was estimated that almost 6,000 families, including agricultural workers and peasants, would be deprived of both their land and livelihood. That was just the beginning of Ratan's woes.

The opposition, led by Mamata Banerjee of the Trinamool Congress, seized the opportunity. It was an ideal opening to earn political capital from